an ethnic designation, insisting instead on ‘Bengali’ to which the great majority of Rohingya could very probably trace their heritage and ancestry’.[77]

The notion that the concept of the ‘Rohingyas’ is a recent construction is one that the regime favours. Jacques Leider is another who argues for this idea. He has written extensively about the Rohingyas and his articles present a variation of the same core arguments propounded by Tonkin. Specifically, he too argues that the name ‘Rohingya’ is a recent construct[78] which has been deliberately adopted by a group who, he contends, really are simply Bengali Muslims. His writings acknowledge that ‘nobody doubts the historical existence of that [Muslim] community’[79] in Arakan, but crucially he argues that the Rohingyas are not descendants of the pre-colonial (that is, pre-1824) community that lived in Arakan. He thus ignores the fact that the Rohingyas are the largest Muslim minority in Myanmar and are concentrated in Rakhine: if they are not the descendants of the pre-1824 community, then who is? He emphasises that the ethnic designation ‘Rohingya’ did not appear in the 1826 census carried out by the British shortly after they conquered the region.[80] But, as we have seen, this is because the British opted to classify on the basis of religion and not ethnicity.

Linked to this, Leider and others argue that the various kingdoms that existed in Arakan from 1300 (when the area again became independent of the kingdoms in central Burma) were Buddhist rather than Muslim and that the population up to 1824 was ethnically Burman. As an example, Leider asserts that the independent kingdom that had existed in the western coastal regions up to 1794 was a Buddhist kingdom: ‘the history of Arakan in the early modern period (15th to 18th centuries) is foremost the history of a Buddhist kingdom’.[81] This state is supposed to have drawn in some Muslims from the neighbouring Bengali kingdom as soldiers, traders or slaves. Leider presents inter-communal relations in this period as involving Muslim and Buddhist communities living ‘side by side’,[82] but says that this harmonious balance was disrupted in the colonial period when the British allowed mass immigration from Bengal.[83] To Leider, the current crisis stems from the belief of many Buddhists in Myanmar that the Rohingyas are outsiders, with no historical rights, but who are astute at manipulating